1. Who would you rather have renting your building?

This or that. Typical neighborhood shopping center.

- Dollar store or furniture store?
- Auto parts store or tire shop?
- Pet groomer or cell phone repair shop?
- Escape room or tutoring center?

If needed: What about the space would change your answer?

2. How much does location matter for these businesses?

Rank 1-10: effect of location on business success.

- Coffee shop
- Dentist
- Auto repair shop
- Accounting firm
- Online retailer's warehouse

If needed: Which could succeed in a cheap, hidden location?

3. Would you buy next door to this?

Yes / no / depends. Buying a small retail property.

- A nightclub
- A hospital
- A school
- A highway entrance
- A large new apartment development

If needed: Who benefits from that neighbor, and who gets hurt?

4. The business applying to rent your space

Green flag / red flag / depends.

- New business with no operating history, but an experienced owner and cash reserves
- Successful elsewhere, but opening its first location in your area
- Wants to fund an expensive buildout itself
- Strong financials, but asks for a short lease
- Wants protection from a competitor moving into the center

If needed: What would you verify before making the decision?

5. How much space should your first business lease?

How do you decide how much space to lease when you don't know how fast the business will grow?

- What do you ask before recommending a size?
- Which needs are real versus wish-list items?
- When is extra space worth paying for?
- What flexibility would you try to negotiate?

6. When is free rent a good deal for the landlord?

- What does the landlord get in return?
- How do you compare the concession with more vacancy?
- What about the tenant changes the calculation?
- When would you advise the owner not to offer it?

If needed: What do you check besides the headline rental rate?

7. What does a busy parking lot actually tell you?

- When is a full lot a good sign?
- When does it make the space harder to lease?
- Which businesses consume parking without helping neighbors?
- What would you look at before drawing a conclusion?

8. What did your first employee let you stop doing?

What was the first role you hired for at Aspire, and why that one?

- What were you doing yourself before the hire?
- How did you decide you could afford it?
- What actually came off your plate?
- Would that still be your first hire today?

Follow the strongest answer: What changed in your own workday?

9. When did Aspire first win against a bigger firm?

Do you remember the first assignment where you beat a much bigger firm?

- What made the client consider you?
- What did you promise that you could actually deliver?
- Why do you think they chose you?
- What did winning that assignment change?

If no specific deal comes to mind: What usually gives a smaller firm a real advantage?

10. Which jobs make you a millionaire? Next part

Rank 1-10: wealth-building potential over a career.

- Firefighter
- Dental hygienist
- Construction manager
- Air traffic controller
- Real estate appraiser

If needed: Does ownership change the answer? Skip any role Brandon doesn't know enough about.

11. Who would you rather lease space from?

This or that; explain what you would check.

- Owner with one building or owner with fifty?
- Local owner or national institution?
- Owner managing directly or third-party manager?
- Longtime owner or someone who just bought the building?

If needed: Which answer changes most for a small business leasing its first space?

12. What deserves the higher rent?

Overrated / underrated for the extra rent.

- A prestigious address
- A brand-new building
- A private entrance
- Reserved parking
- A move-in-ready interior

13. Where would you open your first business?

Good / bad / best; explain the deciding factor.

- Coffee shop: office tower lobby / neighborhood strip center / drive-through site
- Accountant: home office / coworking space / private office suite
- Auto repair: cheap hidden site / expensive main road / established auto-service area

If needed: What would make you reverse the order? There doesn't have to be an objectively bad option.

14. Which business would you want as your neighbor?

Pick the better neighbor for each business.

- Coffee shop: gym or nail salon next door?
- Dentist: pediatrician or restaurant next door?
- Boutique: hair salon or insurance agency next door?
- Office tenant: daycare or fitness studio next door?

If needed: Are you thinking about shared customers, noise, parking, or hours?

15. Should you renew the lease or move?

Your landlord raises your rent, but moving is expensive. How do you decide whether to stay?

- What do you compare beyond monthly rent?
- What moving costs do owners overlook?
- When should you start evaluating alternatives?
- What would make moving worth the disruption?

16. Can a famous tenant still be a risky tenant?

If a household-name business wants your space, should you automatically feel safe?

- Who is actually signing the lease?
- Does a franchise name tell you the operator's financial strength?
- What would you review before accepting?
- When could a local operator be the better choice?

17. Why can the same space lease for two different prices?

Could two tenants reasonably get different deals on the exact same space?

- How does the buildout they need affect the deal?
- How does lease length affect it?
- How do financial strength and guarantees factor in?
- Why can the lower headline rate still be the better deal?

18. What is success at 25 versus 35?

What was your definition of success at 25, and how did it change by 35?

- What milestone were you chasing at 25?
- What did reaching it actually feel like?
- What did running a company change?
- What matters more to you now?

19. What decision did your team change your mind on?

Can you remember a business decision where your team convinced you that you were wrong?

- What did you originally want to do?
- What did they see that you had missed?
- What convinced you to change your mind?
- What happened after you made the decision?

If no example comes to mind: How do you want an employee to challenge your decision?

20. What would you choose early in your career?

This or that for someone starting a career.

- Higher salary with little training or lower salary with a strong mentor?
- Big-name firm with a narrow role or small firm with broad responsibility?
- Immediate commission role or paid apprenticeship first?
- Stay in your hometown or move for the right team?

If needed: Which choice did you personally make, and would you make it again?